

Chapter 10

Instructor's Manual

This chapter covers:

- Features of African American English
- Stereotypes around AAVE and the internal variation among AAVE speakers
- Anglo attitudes towards AAVE
- The complexity of African American attitudes towards AAVE

Sample answers to the questions from the text and the website

From the textbook

1. This chapter doesn't include a discussion of the AAVE speech or expressive language features which are so distinctive. Examples include verbal routines and rituals such as preaching, signifying, boasting, toasting, and call-and-response. Pick one of these and consult the works cited here to compose a brief description with examples.

Sample answer: In *African American English: A Linguistic Introduction*, Lisa Green describes the verbal routine of call-and-response in which the listener responds to each of the statements that the speaker makes. An example of this verbal routine would be in church, when the minister makes a statement and the congregation replies to this statement. Call-and-response is also used in secular situations and has its roots in African cultures.

2. What misconceptions did you have about AAVE before you began reading this chapter and/or any additional reading? Do you think these readings and discussions will have any long-term effect on your own beliefs and reactions?

Sample answer: Before taking this class, I didn't realize that AAVE was as systematic and rule-governed as *SAE in part because I haven't had enough exposure to it to recognize the patterns and also because of standard language ideology. However, now I realize that AAVE just has different rules for grammar and pronunciation than *SAE and that these different rules are not *SAE "mistakes" like I originally thought. These readings and discussions will have a lasting effect on my reactions to AAVE because now I appreciate it as a fully formed language variety rather than "improper" English.

3. If you are a native speaker of AAVE and you are comfortable doing so, take questions from your classmates who are unfamiliar with that language. You must be the one to offer this possibility to the class, so that there is no hint of coercion.

Sample answer: Answers will vary.

4. Read Jordan's (1995b) "Nobody Mean More to Me Than You and the Future Life of Willie Jordan" and prepare to discuss the following issues: (a) How does Jordan's class room method compare to Young's code-meshing approach? How similar or different are her methods and philosophy compared to code-meshing? (b) Do you think her position on AAVE in the classroom is visionary, self-deceptive, naïve, bellicose, ethically sound, unrealistic, all/some/none of the above.

Sample answer: Jordan's classroom method is similar to code-meshing in that AAVE is recognized as a legitimate language variety; however, it is also different because her class focuses on examining the features of AAVE rather than incorporating AAVE into an *SAE classroom with the goal of teaching *SAE to students. I think it's great that she created a class to explore AAVE and encourage students to critically examine the social/political/power issues that are connected with AAVE and *SAE. A class like that would be great for the students to learn about the politics and power hierarchies wrapped up in language ideologies.

5. What would it take to implement a code-meshing approach in public school classrooms? Can you anticipate criticisms or objections and respond to them before the fact?

Sample answer: I think it would take a paradigm shift in this country to implement a code-meshing approach in the classroom. The main objection I anticipate would be the worry that many African American children would not be accepted in an economy so firmly entrenched in standard language ideology. In response to this objection, I would point out that devaluing AAVE while trying to enforce *SAE may actually increase resistance to *SAE as AAVE-speakers insist that their native language variety is valid and see *SAE as a negative force that is attempting to quash their individuality and a major part of their identities. Encouraging the use of both dialects freely in schools would put value on AAVE and encourage AAVE-speakers to express themselves in both language varieties.

6. Compare Price's 2009 sports column to the excerpts from Greene's sports column discussed in this chapter. In both cases, professional sports broadcasters are expressing negative, even racist opinions about professional athletes who are also native AAVE speakers. The journalists who are quoted in Price's column are African American; Greene is not.

Let's be honest. Many of these guys are just flat-out uneducated, which just speaks to the hypocrisy of the 'student-athlete' system. If they tried to go up there and speak properly – without major training – some would be too uncomfortable, nervous and self-conscious to say anything worthwhile. . . . this problem has to be fixed before they get to college – or they've got to undergo some training once they get there. I suspect, though, that some whites are sometimes too scared to correct them for fear of being called racists for "criticizing the way Blacks talk."

- a. How is it that these African American journalists feel entitled or obligated to criticize the athletes' language?

Sample answer: These African American journalists feel entitled or obligated to criticize the athletes' language in part because they use language and therefore, like most people, consider themselves to be experts. But the primary reason is standard language ideology. According to standard language ideology, AAVE is "improper" English, so these columnists think that the athletes should undergo more education to assimilate to the standard language variety.

b. *Do you think it's correct to say that Anglos don't voice similar criticisms because they are afraid of being called racist?*

Sample answer: I think that Anglos actually do often criticize speakers of AAVE because it is widely considered socially acceptable to devalue language varieties (as opposed to social groups).

c. *If Greene's column is racist, as suggested in this chapter, are the Africa - American journalists also being racist?*

Sample answer: The African American journalists are buying into the racist discourses that underlie the devaluation of AAVE.

7. Consider the central question of critical language theory: How do people come to invest in their own unhappiness? Or, as Woodson puts it more emphatically (and perhaps, controversially): "Here we find that the Negro has failed to recover from his slavish habit of berating his own and worshipping others as perfect beings" (Woodson 1933: 84). How do these statements related (1) to each other, and (2) to Greene's and Price's columns?

Sample answer: These statements are related because they can both be applied to the language subordination model and how many African Americans have come to devalue African American English. These statements relate to Greene's and especially Price's column because these columns are a part of the language subordination process by devaluing AAVE and encouraging the African American athletes to speak "proper" English.

8. Read Toni Cade Bambara's short story "My Man Bovanne," which is told from the point of view of a middle-aged African American woman in conflict with her adult children. Note how AAVE is used for the dialog of some characters but not others. Bambara is a native AAVE speaker, and made those decisions consciously.

a. *Given the overall theme of the story, how does the variable use of AAVE serve to illustrate the conflict?*

Sample answer: The variable use of AAVE illustrates the conflict between the mother and her children because the mother uses AAVE features but her children do not. The linguistic divide between them helps to highlight their rift.

b. *How many features of AAVE described in this chapter can you identify in "My Man Bovanne?" Are there other features that are not described here?*

Sample answer: This short story has several features of AAVE described in Chapter 10, including double negative constructions (“Didn nobody ask me nuthin.”), copula deletion (“Cause he blind and old”), the deletion of voiced stops at the end of words (“Cause this was the child of our happiness fore Mr. Peoples die”), the use of *axe* instead of *ask* (“I’m axin you all a simple question), and the deletion of the third person singular -s (““Oh damn,’ Elo say and go through the swingin door).”

From the website

Audio

1. Listen of the samples from African American speakers from several states. Do you notice any variation in the language varieties used by these speakers?

Sample answer: Yes, I hear a lot of variation in these speech samples. First of all, I hear regional variation. For example, Texas 17 has features of southern English in addition to AAVE features, whereas Michigan 9 does not sound southern. In addition, there is variation in the amount of AAVE features used. For example, Alabama 9 has very few features of AAVE (and very few features of southern English in my opinion), whereas Mississippi 3 has many more features of AAVE (and southern English). I also noticed that the speakers tended to have more AAVE features when they were engaged in the casual conversation at the end of the clip than when they were reading the passage, which shows that there is contextual variation in AAVE as well. The range of these speech samples demonstrate that AAVE is not a homogenous language variety and has many different sub-varieties.

2. Listen to the samples of other dialects of English other than AAVE and consult the description of some features of AAVE provided on pages 183. Do you hear any of those features in the non-AAVE dialects?

Sample answer: Yes, I do. For example, West Virginia 1 uses consonant cluster reduction, pronouncing the word *district* as *distric*, and also monophthongizes the diphthong /ai/ in the word *I*. In addition, New York 6 and England 35 both delete /r/ in words such as *north* and *her*.

Video

“Obama Inaugural Speech Translated into Ebonics”
Funny or Die

<http://www.funnyordie.com/videos/02ae432358/obama-inaugural-speech-translated-into-ebonics>

1. What does this video reveal about attitudes toward “Ebonics” and the people who speak it?

Sample answer: I think this video was created to mock African American English, with, as Lippi-Green says on page 187, “the apparent purpose of highlighting how very different AAVE is from ‘good’ or ‘proper’ English.” Translating a presidential speech – which I think most people would consider as very standard English – into a parody of AAVE helps to make the point that AAVE is very different from this standard, and therefore is “bad” or “improper”

English. This video also reveals unflattering stereotypes of people who speak AAVE. For example, the “Ebonics” translation of the speech is confrontational towards President Bush and the crowd attending the inaugural address, talks about “bitch slapping” and “beat downs,” refers to drinking, gun-toting, and pimps collecting money from prostitutes. This video sends the message that people who speak AAVE are prone to violence and other vices. This mocking translation mirrors what Smitherman (1998/1999, p. 84; quoted on p. 187) said about the impression that African American English was “the lingo of criminals, dope pushers, teenage hoodlums, and various and sundry hustlers, who spoke in ‘muthafuckas’ and ‘pussy-copping raps.’” In fact, this video uses the word *muthafuckas* several times.

Suggested activities and discussion questions

1. Ask your students what types of public figures they think use AAVE the most on television (e.g. politicians, actors, athletes, musicians, writers, newscasters, etc.). Why do they think some groups use AAVE more than others?
2. Ask your students to take notes on any use of AAVE while they watch TV over a set time period. Encourage them to note who uses AAVE, as well as the context of the utterance and some general information about what features of AAVE were used. For example, did the speaker use general intonational features, pronunciations, or grammatical features of AAVE? Can your students find any patterns in their data? Ask them to reflect on what they found and how they think their findings reflect standard language ideology.
3. As a class or individually, read the anonymous letter found at this website:
http://letters.salon.com/news/feature/2007/12/10/obama_oprah/permalink/ea38062f5521190c6ba33f28b7f959f1.html

Then read this article about African American English entitled “Performing ‘truth’: Black speech acts”: http://findarticles.com/p/articles/mi_m2838/is_2_36/ai_89872238/

Discuss the differences in the perspectives expressed in these two websites. Which point of view do the students identify with more? Why do they feel the way they do?

Next, ask the students to discuss the following quote from “Performing ‘truth’: Black speech acts” in light of what they have learned in this course:

For those individuals whose daily demands require a reliance on “mainstream,” standardized speech acts, the purposeful invocation of Black Speak can be a powerful statement about identity, community, connectedness to the counter/alternative culture, and the oration as well as the perception of a “truth.”

4. To enhance discussion of this chapter, please visit the companion website and check out the audio and video clips available for use in your classroom.